tearing Pakistan apart. According to another classified report compiled by the CIA after the Bangladesh war,

> In fact, China did much less for Pakistan in 1971 than they had done during the Indian-Pakistani war of 1965. This time the Chinese avoided diversionary actions on the Indian-Chinese border. In contrast to 1965, they kept their border patrolling down, avoided moving bombers into Tibet, and made only pro forma protests of alleged Indian violations well after the event. In this way, the Chinese reduced any Indian concern about Chinese intervention—concern which, the Chinese reasoned, might induce New Delhi to allow the Soviets an enlarged role in South Asia.[57]

Another plausible reason for the Chinese inaction could be problems at home. The leadership in Beijing was shattered by the sudden death of Lin Biao, and Mao himself is said to have been depressed and become a recluse after the possible betrayal by someone who until then had been considered his anointed successor. Mao turned to some of his old comrades, ultra-leftists whom he had denounced in the past. Wang Hongwen, a 38-year-old cadre from Shanghai, was brought to Beijing and made CCP vice-chairman. But Mao was ailing, and his wife, Jiang Qing, was in charge when he was unable to provide the CCP with any kind of coherent guidance. She brought in propaganda specialists Zhang Chunqiao and Yao Wenyuan—and the quartet later became known under the pejorative label ‘The Gang of Four’. They saw Deng Xiaoping with his—by CCP standards—moderate views as the main threat to their grip on power. He was asked to take part in a series of self-criticism sessions, admitted to a number of ideological mistakes, and Mao, siding with his wife and her three companions, asked the CCP’s Central Committee to ‘discuss Deng’s mistakes thoroughly’.[58]

At that time, the top leadership was getting decimated as one revolutionary veteran after another died. The first to pass away was the notorious Kang Sheng. He died of bladder cancer on 16 December 1975, and the official media spared no praise at his funeral. Kang was ‘a proletarian revolutionary, a Marxist theoretician, and a glorious fighter against revisionism’.[59]

Zhou Enlai and Mao had been too weak to attend, and of those two, Zhou died first. He suffered from bladder cancer as well, and it took his life on 8 January 1976. Mao was absent, but Deng Xiaoping, who was on his way back into power, delivered a speech at this state funeral on 15 January. The death of Kang was probably not mourned by many, but in April, huge